

UNDERWHELMING MP Congress chief Jitu Patwari, left, at a presser in Bhopal, Nov. 14

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MP CONGRESS

JITU ON THE BACK FOOT

By Rahul Noronha

On December 16, 2023, the Congress had announced Jitendra 'Jitu' Patwari as their new Madhya Pradesh state president, signalling a generational change as he replaced veteran Kamal Nath. Patwari took over just after the somewhat humiliating defeat in the assembly poll, where the party won just 66 out of 230 seats—a near-halving of its 2018 tally of 114, that too in a poll many pundits believed the Congress should have won. Almost a year into office, has Patwari managed to deliver? Well, it hasn't been a smooth ride.

Patwari's biggest hindrance has been the lack of acceptance among a section of Congress leaders. He seems to have fostered a tactical alliance with ex-CM Digvijaya Singh, but that's about it. Nath has been keeping away from state politics while other senior leaders like Ajay Singh and Laxman Singh have been vocal about the "lack of balance" in the 335-member state executive announced in late October. At least five of the 'senior' appointees have refused to take up their assignments, terming it beneath them.

The fact that the Congress's electoral fortunes have not improved will also hurt. Under Patwari's watch, the party drew a blank in the general election with his hand-picked candidate in Indore, Akshay Bam, defecting to the BJP in the middle of electioneering. Three party MLAs also scooted over ahead of the Lok Sabha poll. Later, in the first post-LS election bypoll in Amarwara, the BJP won, denting Nath's fortress in Chhindwara and doing nothing positive for Patwari. The results of the two latest byelections, held on November 20 in Vijaypur and Budhni, too, will become talking points that will govern Patwari's destiny.

Patwari's USP was his agitation-centred politics and he did launch a farm-centric strike in the monsoon months which received a mixed response, but with no follow-up, any gains have been whittled away. The state is facing a major fertiliser shortage, but there has been no ground-level action by the principal opposition party. Patwari also organised an agitation against atrocities on women and other marginalised groups, but it, too, did not catch the people's imagination. "Unless something is done to build up the organisation from the grassroots, all changes will be cosmetic," says a Congress MLA from the Bundelkhand region. That gospel truth, it seems, is yet to sink in. ■

GCCs

TECH TWO: THE NEW FRONTIER

By Sonal Khetarpal

India is slowly but surely transitioning from its old role as a digital factory yard for the world. There's an upstream shift along the value chain to a more knowledge-based role as ideator and innovator. The new buzzword is Global Capability Centres or GCCs. Offshore hubs that deliver technology, engineering and operational support to their parent multinationals, the new functionality goes way beyond that of a technological sweat shop. Take Swiss multinational Roche's Digital Centre of Excellence in Pune, for instance. It's driving the biotech giant's efforts to harness technology and data to automate processes and machines in diagnostic labs. This focus on high-value innovation from India underscores how companies are tapping into the country's talent to power their research and development.

With several Fortune 500 companies planning to establish GCCs in India, state governments are introducing new GCC policies to attract more centres and create jobs. While Karnataka launched a GCC policy this week, Tamil Nadu is planning its own.

India is presently the world's largest base for GCCs, hosting over 1,700 centres as of FY24—over half the global count—and employing more than 1.9 million people, according to the India GCC Landscape Report by NASSCOM and Zinnov. Over 50 per cent of these centres have shifted to high-value work, while 24 per cent have scaled up their operations in the past five years. "In less than two years since our inception in India,

INDIA HOSTS NEARLY 50 PER CENT OF THE WORLD'S GCCs. MNCs AIM TO LEVERAGE THE COUNTRY'S ROBUST SERVICES INDUSTRY AND ABUNDANT TALENT POOL